Indie Startup Economics: What 8,782 Founders Reveal

A data-driven analysis of bootstrapped startups tracked by TrustMRR — revenue-verified, category-tagged, and geographically diverse. Snapshot: July 30, 2026.

The Dataset at a Glance

TrustMRR is a revenue-verification directory connecting directly to Stripe, RevenueCat, and similar APIs. Each row is a real company with verified revenue and metadata — not self-reported estimates.

8,782

Startups Tracked

Verified listings with revenue metadata

22%

Listed for Sale

1,952 marketplace listings

59%

Use Stripe

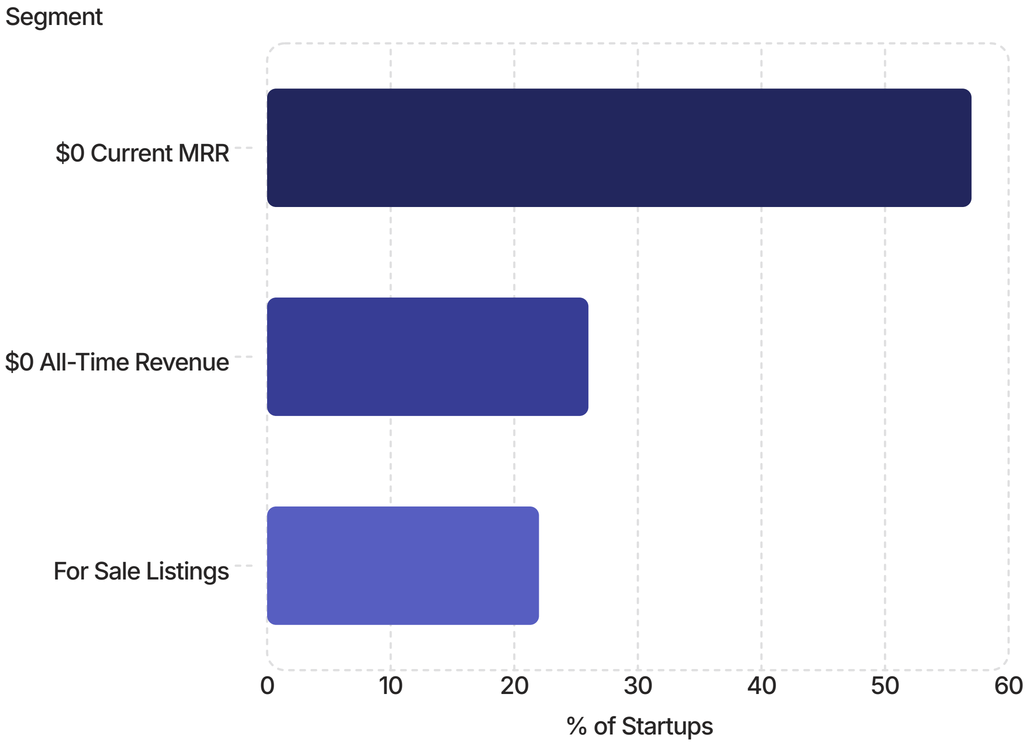
Dominant payment infrastructure

36%

Country Unknown

Unlabeled geographic data

A Power-Law Market, Not a Normal Distribution



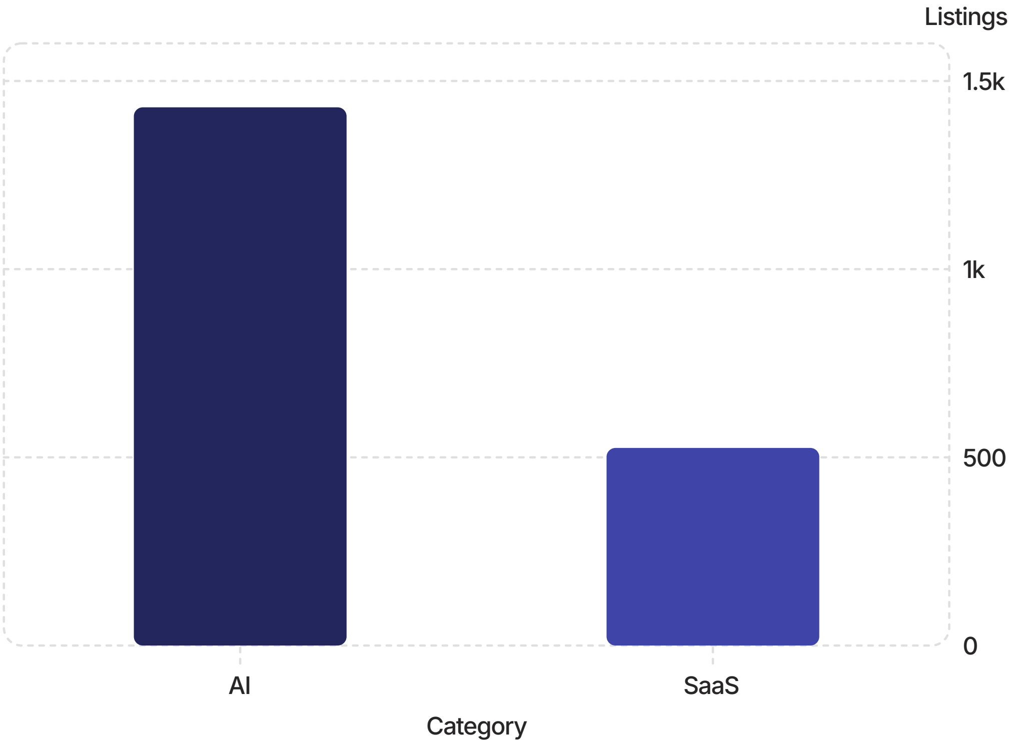
The Outlier Problem

The #1 earner, **Stan**, generates **$3.57M MRR** and **$76.6M all-time revenue** — while the median startup earns **$0/month**.

Mean MRR ($1,752) is **over 20× the 75th percentile** ($76). A handful of outliers drag the average. **Median, not mean, is the honest summary statistic here.**

> 57% report $0 current MRR — mostly pre-revenue or dormant projects tracked for transparency.

AI Dominates by Volume — But Not by Revenue Quality



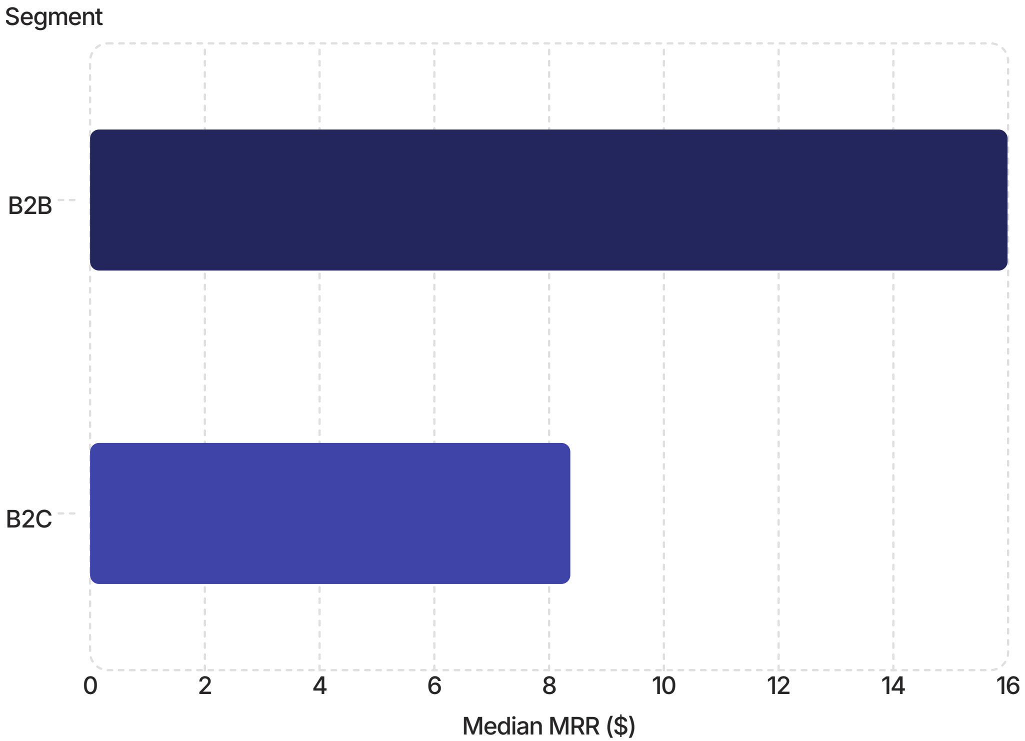
The AI Paradox

AI leads with **1,430 listings (~16% of dataset)** — over 2.7× the next-largest category, SaaS (525).

Yet AI's median MRR is only **$16.90** — mid-pack, well behind **Mobile Apps ($57.10)** and **Health & Fitness ($20.52)**.

The AI segment is thick with early-stage and experimental projects. Smaller, less-hyped categories skew toward more established, monetizing products.

B2B Out-Earns B2C — But B2C Outnumbers It



Willingness to Pay vs. Builder Frequency

B2B startups have nearly **2× the median MRR** of B2C ($15.99 vs $8.37), consistent with typical enterprise willingness-to-pay differences.

However, B2C listings **outnumber B2B nearly 2-to-1** (3,143 vs 1,883). Consumer apps are simply more common to build and list — even though they monetize less per company.

Geography: US, India & Europe Lead

🇺🇸 United States

1,657 listings — largest by far

🇮🇳 India

807 listings — second place

🇫🇷 France

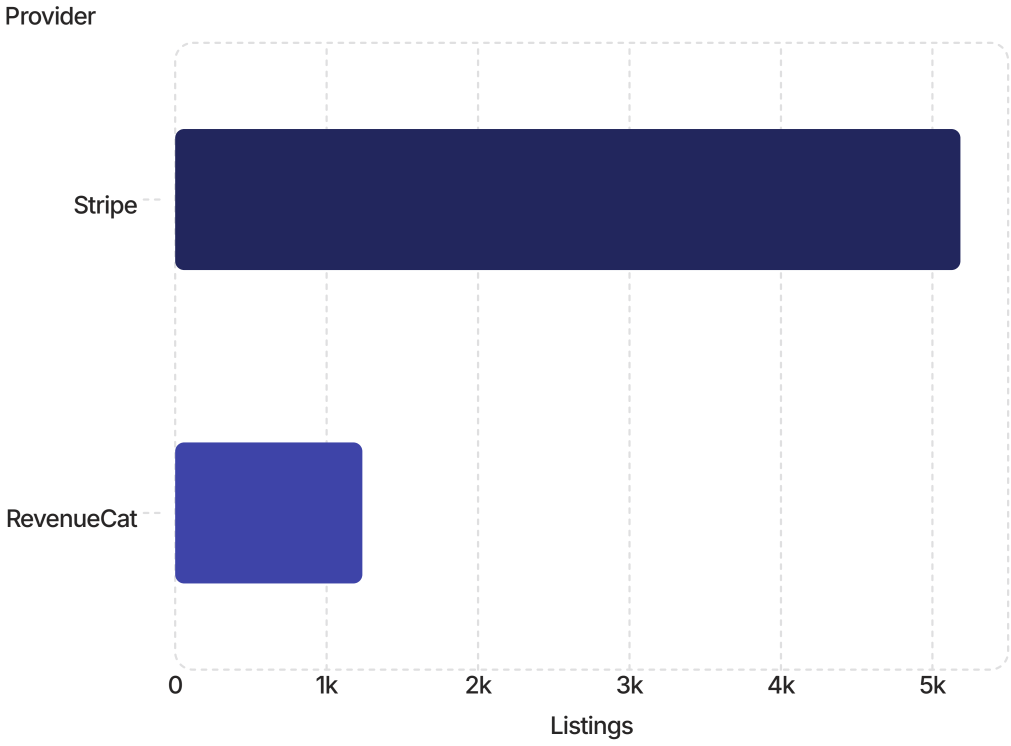
612 listings — strong EU presence

🇬🇧 United Kingdom

603 listings — close behind France

These four countries account for roughly **45% of all rows with known country**. A significant 36% of listings have no labeled country — a data gap worth noting for geographic analysis.

Stripe Is the Infrastructure Backbone



Payment Infrastructure Concentration

Stripe underlies **59% of all listings** (5,185 of 8,782). RevenueCat — focused on mobile subscriptions — is a distant second at 1,236.

This reflects that the dataset likely draws heavily on Stripe's public API for revenue verification, which may introduce a subtle bias toward Stripe-native businesses.

Payment processor data can serve as a rough proxy for business maturity and subscription model sophistication.

The "For Sale" Market: Small, Early Deals

1,952 Listings — But Modest Stakes

Roughly **22% of the dataset** is listed for sale, but the deals are small:

Most marketplace activity here is in **tiny, early-stage acquisitions** rather than meaningful exits.

Median Asking Price

Just **$5,000** — early-stage territory

Median MRR of Listings

Only **~$1.90/month** — mostly pre-revenue or dormant

Key Takeaways & Data Caveats

1. **Use median, not mean**

   Power-law distribution makes mean MRR misleading — outliers dominate the average.

2. **AI volume ≠ AI revenue quality**

   AI leads in listings but trails Mobile Apps and Health & Fitness in median MRR.

3. **B2B earns more; B2C is more common**

   Nearly 2× median MRR for B2B, but B2C listings outnumber B2B 2-to-1.

4. **Ignore vanity metrics for due diligence**

   Domain Authority and social followers show weak correlation with actual revenue.

Data quality note: Growth-percentage fields have extreme outliers (max 30D growth: 1,230,899%) likely from small-denominator effects. Treat with caution — don't average directly.